

We added more agents. **It got worse.**

Multi-agent: help vs. hurt. Why most multi-agent systems are premature — and the one question that tells you when they're not.

Swipe →

Four specialists. One incoherent whole.

Planner. Mapper. Validator. Executor. Clean separation — just like microservices.

- > mapper changed the schema; planner never saw it
- > validator checked assumptions the executor had dropped
- > two agents ran the SAME step

We spent more time reconciling the agents with each other than doing the migration.

It borrows credibility it hasn't earned.

- **The microservices analogy** — we decompose big systems, so decompose big agents.
- **“Specialists are better”** — a tight validation agent beats a generalist.
- **The parallelism dream** — five agents must be faster than one.

All reasonable. All applied to the **wrong layer.**

Microservices pass payloads. Agents must pass **context**.

A schema or API crosses a boundary cleanly. The fuzzy, evolving understanding of *what we're doing and why* does not.

Every handoff leaks shared understanding. Each agent acts on a partial view — **locally sensible, globally wrong.**

Three costs stack up fast.

- **Compounding errors** — across four agents, mistakes don't add. They multiply.
- **~15× the tokens** — context gets re-sent and re-reasoned at every seam.
- **Debugging collapses** — the bug lives in the *conversation*, not any one agent.

When it wins decisively.

Breadth-first, parallelizable, context-independent work: many subtasks that run at once, don't depend on each other, share no evolving state.

“Research these 40 companies.”

“Assess 500 tenants against a fixed checklist.”

Fan out → run in parallel → merge. No shared context to fragment.

One question decides it.

Do the subtasks need to **talk to each other** while they run?

NO →

Fan them out. Multi-agent wins.

YES →

A coordination problem in a parallelism costume. One agent wins.

The migration was a loud **YES**. That's why it broke.

A “should you go multi-agent?” decision tree.

Genuinely parallel? Context-independent?
Worth the $\sim 15\times$ tax? Has a single agent
actually hit a wall? Any “no” $\rightarrow$ one agent.

Full post + the decision tree — link in the comments.

Start single-threaded. Make the second agent earn it. Next: Part 7 — Learning from Production.